In the 1930s and 1940s, Stalin perfected the totalitarian system he inherited. The Stalinist network was composed of three main branches. First, there was the governmental apparatus of state ministries, regional administrations and regular Red Army units, which in 1939 comprised 1.6 million civilian officials[71] and 1.9 million soldiers.[72] Second, there was the apparatus of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union and its ubiquitous party cells, which in 1939 included 2.4 million party members.[73] Third, there was the secret police: first known as the Cheka, in Stalin's days it was called the OGPU, NKVD and MGB, and after Stalin's death it morphed into the KGB. Its post-Soviet successor organisation has been known since 1995 as the FSB. In 1937, the NKVD had 270,000 agents and millions of informers.[74]

The three branches operated in parallel. Just as democracy is maintained by having overlapping self-correcting mechanisms that keep each other in check, modern totalitarianism created overlapping surveillance mechanisms that keep each other in order. The governor of a Soviet province was constantly watched by the local party commissar, and neither of them knew who among their staff was an NKVD informer. A testimony to the effectiveness of the system is that modern totalitarianism largely solved the perennial problem of premodern autocracies – revolts by provincial subordinates. While the USSR had its share of court coups, not once did a provincial governor or a Red Army front commander rebel against the centre.[75] Much of the credit for that goes to the secret police, which kept a close eye on the mass of citizens, on provincial administrators and even more so on the party and the Red Army.

While in most polities throughout history the army had wielded enormous political power, in twentieth-century totalitarian regimes the regular army ceded much of its clout to the secret police – the information army. In the USSR, the Cheka, OGPU, NKVD and KGB lacked the firepower of the Red Army, but had more influence in the Kremlin and could terrorise and purge even the army brass. The East German Stasi and the Romanian Securitate were similarly stronger than the regular armies of these countries.[76] In Nazi Germany, the SS was more powerful than the Wehrmacht, and the SS chief, Heinrich Himmler, was higher up the pecking order than Wilhelm Keitel, chief of the Wehrmacht high command.